CFLMUN'26

Combating Against Italian Mafias

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STUDY GUIDE

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1. LETTER FROM THE SECRETARY GENERAL

Dear Delegates,

Welcome to CFLMUN'26, everyone! My name is Sümeyra, and I have the honour of serving as the Secretary General at this conference. I'm filled with excitement and happiness. Also, I'd like to thank my Head of Academy Belinay Takcı, my Head of Crisis Mete Mercan, my Under Secretary General Hira Sağlam and my academic assistant İdil Coşkun for helping to organize the committee.

In the International Criminal Police Organization Committee, INTERPOL, you will go down details about to the Italian mafias and have a pleasant semi-crisis committee experience

Also, I want to say thank you to each and every one of you for choosing to be a part of this committee. Your presence and participation are what will make it truly meaningful. I look forward to seeing you all between May 1st and 3rd, ready to challenge perspectives, defend positions, and most importantly, enjoy the experience.

Wishing you all the best of luck. *Let's shape the future in the light of diplomacy!*

Warm regards,

Sümeyra Gülsüm Çolak

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2. LETTER FROM THE HEAD OF ACADEMY

Distinguished delegates,

It is a great honour to welcome you to the first edition of CFLMUN. Over the course of this conference, you will engage in thoughtful debate, share perspectives, and develop solutions to complex global issues. In a world shaped by conflict and uncertainty, your voice carries weight. The responsibility to think critically and act thoughtfully belongs to you. As delegates, you are not only participants in debate, but contributors to ideas that shape perspectives beyond this room.

Your dedication to preparing for this conference already shows your commitment to building a better future. Use this opportunity to challenge your critical thinking, refine your voice, and explore perspectives different from your own. We look forward to seeing the creativity, determination, and insight you bring to your committees.

It's essential not to forget that the experience you acquire here will stay with you for years to come. Make the most of every moment, both inside and outside your committee sessions. Do not hesitate to seek guidance whenever you need it.

Your seat is ready. We are eager to hear your ideas.

Sincerely,

Belinay Takcı

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3. LETTER FROM THE ACADEMIC ASSISTANT OF INTERPOL

Dear Fellow Delegates,

First, I would like to welcome you to the first edition of CFLMUN and to our INTERPOL committee, where you will be debating the agenda item: Combating Italian Mafias.

Organized crime is one of the biggest threats to global safety. In this committee, you will focus on major Italian mafias, whose origins date back to the 19th century and which have now grown into international networks. Through drug trafficking, money laundering, and corruption, these groups affect the economies and governments of other countries beyond Italy's borders.

During the sessions, you will aim to find solutions to combat these mafias by debating and working together. We also want you to look at the past efforts to combat these organizations, some of which are included in our study guide, and propose new and realistic strategies to stop them.

We look forward to hearing your ideas and solutions throughout the debate. If you have any questions about the study guide or the committee, feel free to contact me by email.

I wish you all the best for the sessions ahead.

Best regards,

İdil Coşkun

Academic Assistant of INTERPOL

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4. INTRODUCTION TO THE COMMITTEE

a. What Is INTERPOL?

INTERPOL, which stands for the International Criminal Police Organization, is an intergovernmental organization that facilitates international police cooperation and crime control. With seven regional bureaus worldwide and a National Central Bureau in each of its 196 member states, its General Secretariat is located in Lyon, France. As the world's largest international police organization, INTERPOL aims to promote the widest possible connection among criminal police authorities and to establish institutions that contribute to the prevention and suppression of international crime. The organization has four official languages: Arabic, English, French, and Spanish.

While providing investigative support, expertise, and training to law enforcement agencies worldwide, INTERPOL focuses on three major areas of transnational crime: terrorism, cybercrime, and organized crime. Crimes such as crimes against humanity, child sexual abuse material (CSAM), drug trafficking and production, corruption, intellectual property infringement, and white-collar crime fall within INTERPOL's broad mandate. Through the usage of criminal databases, crime information centers, and communications networks, the organization facilitates collaboration among law enforcement institutions. Although often misunderstood as a global police force, INTERPOL is not a law enforcement agency and has no power to arrest.

Most of INTERPOL's annual budget—approximately €142 million ($155 million)—is funded through statutory contributions from its member countries. The General Assembly, made up of representatives from all member states, elects the Executive Committee and the president—currently Lucas Philippe of France—to oversee INTERPOL's policies and administration. With a workforce of around 1,000 personnel from over 100 countries, which includes both police officers and civilians, operations are carried out by the General Secretariat, led by the Secretary-General, currently Valdezy Urquiza, the former Vice President of INTERPOL for the Americas.

According to its constitution, INTERPOL remains strictly politically neutral and is prohibited from intervening or participating in matters of a political, military, religious, or racial nature.

b. History of INTERPOL

INTERPOL was founded on 7 September 1923 at the conclusion of a five-day International Police Congress in Vienna under the name International Criminal Police Commission (ICPC), following a significant rise in international crime. Johann Schober, who was the head of the Vienna police, was elected as the first president of the ICPC. The organization's headquarters were established in Vienna. INTERPOL assumed many of its modern functions during the 1930s. After the Nazis seized control of the organization, it experienced near-complete stagnation until the end of World War II. In 1956, the ICPC adopted a new constitution and took the name INTERPOL, derived from its telegraph address used since 1946.

5. INTRODUCTION TO THE AGENDA ITEM

a. Background of the Agenda Item

The Mafia is a social phenomenon that takes the form of a planned and structured criminal organization, aiming to commit crime for economic gain. The origins of mafia-type organizations in Italy trace back to the second half of the 19th century, in a region distinguished by its uniqueness and diversity, shortly after the end of Roman influence. These included the Camorra in Campania, the 'Ndrangheta in Calabria, and the Sicilian Mafia (Cosa Nostra) in Sicily—all emerged in the midst of a crumbling feudal system where old relations of production had not yet died and the new ones had not yet been born.

Graphics of the statistics of organized crime in Italy:

Until the 1960s, mafia activity in Italy focused on the control, extortion, and smuggling of agricultural goods. After World War II, the geographic and economic scope of mafia activities changed along with Italy's wider political and economic transformations. Developments in other countries like the USA and France, especially the ones about Italy, also influenced the growth of mafia organizations. As the mafia's system of governing organized crime expanded and entrenched, Italy began to create legal frameworks to combat organized crime through democratic means. The first significant step was taken with the establishment of the Parliamentary Anti-Mafia Commission in 1962-63, which remains active today, with the first detailed legal academic reports. Despite internal skepticism within the commission, these studies aimed to demonstrate the real existence of the mafia phenomenon and to characterize its structure to develop appropriate strategies for intervention. One of the most important and influential reports, both within and outside of the commission, was published in 1976. This report, authored by the members of the Parliament (MPs)—Cesare Terranova and Pio La Torre—was supported by only six MPs and senators and definitely pointed to the links between the political parties and the mafia. It also articulated for the first time what would later be the core of Italy's anti-mafia criminal policy: targeting the profits.

One of the earliest laws dealing with organized crime—without specifically naming mafia-type groups—was Law No. 1423/56, entitled "Preventive Measures Against Persons Dangerous to Public

Safety and Morality" which came into force in 1956 and was repealed in 2011. Approximately ten years later, Law No. 575/65 was passed, introducing provisions that allowed for preventive measures to be taken against individuals suspected of mafia-related crimes. These laws, along with the reports of the Parliamentary Anti-Mafia Commission and Pio La Torre's political and trade union work, led to a legislative draft that transformed Italy's fight against organized crime. Pio La Torre became a target of the Sicilian Mafia due to his determined efforts in judicial, political, and social initiatives to combat organized crime and was murdered on April 30, 1982, in Palermo, his hometown, along with another member of the party.

Following Pia La Torre's assassination, the massacre continued. In an attempt to respond to the worsening situation, national authorities sent General Carlo Alberto Dalla Chiesa as governor, tasked with stopping the bloodshed. Just four months later, Dalla Chiesa and his wife were murdered by assassins sent by the Sicilian Mafia. As a response, the Italian Parliament passed Law No. 646/1982 on September 13, 1982.

Magistrate Rocco Chinnici assembled a group of prosecutors and judges to form a special team to investigate and prove the diversity of the criminal activities of mafia organizations (particularly the Sicilian Mafia) in 1983. The investigations of this anti-mafia group culminated in 1987, based on indictments and demands for trial led by Giovanni Falcone and Paolo Borsellino; a court convicted more than 350 mafia members in the Maxi Trial, handing down a total of 2,665 years in prison, excluding life sentences. After the appointment of a judge nearing retirement with no experience in anti-mafia investigations, the successful anti-mafia pool was disintegrated.

In the following years, a determined section of the Italian judiciary continued the investigations and began to expose deep collusion between the mafia and business and political sectors. This situation created an environment that led to confusion, accusations, lies, and more assassinations. The central figure of the fight against the mafia was Giovanni Falcone. Facing increasing obstacles in his investigations, he accepted the position of Director of Criminal Affairs at the Ministry of Justice in Rome. He proposed establishing two important institutions: Direzione Investigativa Antimafia (DIA) and the Direzione Nazionale Antimafia (DNA). He succeeded; the institutions were established in 1991 by Decree Laws No. 345 and 367, with the aim of improving and coordinating judicial investigations. On May 23, 1992, Giovanni Falcone and his wife, along with magistrate Francesca Morvillo and three of their bodyguards, were murdered. Fifty-seven days later, Paolo Borsellino was assassinated along with five of his escorts, knowing he was also going to be murdered. In those final weeks, Borsellino publicly condemned the mafia's political and business ties. The murders sparked widespread outrage throughout Italy and especially in the USA, Spain, and France, forcing the Italian state to implement measures previously proposed by Falcone to intensify the fight against the mafia.

A photograph of Giovanni Falcone and Paolo Borsellino taken on 27 March 1992 by Tony Gentile during a conference:

Between the Falcone and Borsellino murders, Decree Law No. 306/92 amended Article 41bis of the special prison regime. This decree, which came into effect after Borsellino's death, allowed for the suspension of prisoners' rights to prevent them from transmitting orders from prison to the outside world. In 1992, with the help of the social organization Libera, Law No. 109/1996 was passed. This law made it possible for the state or civil society to reuse mafia assets seized under the Rognoni-La Torre law for social purposes. Another significant step in the development of the implementation of anti-organizational crime tools in Italy is Law No. 4/2010, which established the National Agency for the Management and Distribution of Assets Seized and Confiscated from Organized Crime (ANBSC). Through this agency, approximately 60,000 properties, five companies, and hundreds of thousands of movable assets seized from mafia organizations are protected, managed, and properly distributed. Following 46 years of efforts by broad sectors of the judiciary, politics, and civil society, Italy embarked on a process of organizing and consolidating the numerous anti-mafia laws and regulations that had been enacted during that time.

In 2011, the Italian Anti-Mafia Law officially came into force with Decree Law No. 159/2011. The first fifteen articles of the law outline personal preventive measures aimed at preventing criminal activities of individuals suspected of belonging to mafia organizations. Articles 16 to 34 summarize the procedures for seizing and confiscating assets that may be the product or proceeds of mafia-related activities. Articles 34 to 54 describe the system for safekeeping and utilizing seized or confiscated assets. Subsequent articles, up to article 114, regulate the management of anti-mafia documents generated during investigations and define the procedures for dissolving and managing local administrations seized by the mafia. Finally, the law contains general provisions regulating the operation of DNA, DIA, and ANBSC. This Anti-Mafia Law also inspired other countries, such as Argentina and Spain.

b. Major Italian Mafias

Camorra: The Camorra, which is an Italian Mafia-type criminal organization and society, emerged in the region of Campania and is one of the oldest and largest criminal organizations in Italy, dating back to the 18th century. As the Camorra's influence and power grew in the 19th century, its activities expanded to include various types of crimes such as smuggling, blackmail, extortion, and highway robbery. The Camorra's organizational structure is divided into separate groups called "clans." Clan leaders, called "capo" or "boss," have dozens or hundreds of members depending on the clan's power

and structure. It is not unusual for the Camorra to permeate into the politics of their related fields, whose main businesses are drug trafficking, racketeering, counterfeiting, and money laundering. Since the early 1980s and its involvement in drug trafficking, the Camorra has established a strong presence in other European countries, especially in Spain. Camorra clans are often in close contact with South American drug cartels, facilitating the arrival of drugs in Europe. According to a speech given by Naples prosecutor Giovanni Melillo to the Antimafia Commission in 2023, the most powerful groups of the Camorra today are the Mazzarella clan and the Secondigliano Alliance. The latter is an alliance of the Licciardi, Contini, and Mallardo clans. Unlike their counterparts, the Sicilian Mafia and the 'Ndrangheta, Camorra bosses generally have a very high profile, a flamboyant lifestyle, and excessive spending. In recent years, the Camorra has been particularly focused on recruiting children, and there are no signs that this trend will stop or change in the future. These children constitute a significant source of manpower that clan leaders exploit for their own purposes. Given the constant arrests of clan leaders, it is likely that young Camorra members will take their place. And for their recent activities, various Camorra clans have allegedly formed alliances with Nigerian drug cartels and the Albanian mafia. Augusto La Torre, a former leader of the La Torre clan and a confessor, is married to an Albanian woman; the first foreign confessor, a Tunisian, admitted to having ties to the feared Casalesi clan in Casal di Principe. The first town where the Camorra allowed a foreign clan to rule was Castel Volturno, given to the Rapace clans from Lagos and Benin City in Nigeria. This connection allowed them to send cocaine and women slaves to Europe.

'Ndrangheta: The 'Ndrangheta, which is an Italian mafia-type criminal organization that emerged in the region of Calabria in the 19th century, has developed into one of the world's most dangerous, powerful, and prevalent organized crime groups. The basic structure of the organization, which has a decentralized, horizontal structure and consists of autonomous business units known as 'ndrine, is based on family and blood ties. From the mid-20th century onwards, coinciding with significant migrations from Calabria, the 'Ndrangheta clans expanded their activities to Northern and Central Italy, Europe, Australia, and the USA. The association was reportedly involved in a wide range of illegal activities, which are drug trafficking, smuggling, money laundering, extortion, racketeering, and usury. Until the 1960s, the 'Ndrangheta had confined its activities in Italy, particularly in Calabria, focusing mainly on extortion and blackmail. Their involvement in cigarette smuggling expanded their sphere of influence and facilitated contact with the Sicilian Mafia and Camorra. With the initiation of large public works projects in Calabria, the embezzlement of revenues from public contracts became a significant source of income. The 'Ndrangheta is estimated to be responsible for more than 200 kidnappings between the 1970s and the mid-1990s. The 'Ndrangheta has historically demonstrated the capacity to exert significant influence over local, regional, and national politics through systematic corruption, coercion, and collusion. It is known to have permeated various sectors of the legal economy both within Italy and internationally. Estimates in 2013 showed the organization's income had reached 53 billion euros. A 2010 US diplomatic cable estimated that the 'Ndrangheta's illegal activities, such as drug trafficking, extortion, and money laundering, accounted for approximately three percent of Italy's Gross Domestic Product (GDP). Although its origins are contemporary with the Sicilian Mafia, the 'Ndrangheta was only officially legally defined as a mafia-type organization under Article 416 bis of the Italian Penal Code in 2010. In March 2010, the Italian Supreme Court of Appeals reached a similar conclusion. The 'Ndrangheta still run their illegal activities, especially drug trafficking. Italian investigators estimate that approximately 80% of Europe's cocaine passes through the port of Gioia Tauro in Calabria and is controlled by the 'Ndrangheta. It also profited from the cocaine boom in South America. This group has transformed into a multi-billion dollar business

operating globally. UNODC estimated that the amount of cocaine seized in Spain in 2007 (approximately 28 metric tons) was almost ten times greater than that seized in Italy. The 'Ndrangheta is reportedly investing illicit gains in legitimate real estate and financial ventures. According to estimates by the Italian private research institute Eurispes, the 'Ndrangheta's business volume in 2007 was approximately €44 billion. This figure represented approximately 2.9% of Italy's GDP.

Estimated Total Turnover of the 'Ndrangheta in 2007:

Illicit activity	Income
Drug trafficking	€ 27.240 billion
Commercial enterprise and public contracts	€ 5.733 billion
Extortion and usury	€ 5.017 billion
Arms trafficking	€ 2.938 billion
Prostitution and human trafficking	€ 2.867 billion
Total	€ **43.795** billion

Sicilian Mafia (Cosa Nostra): The Sicilian Mafia, or Cosa Nostra (also known as the Mafia), which is an Italian mafia-type criminal organization and society, emerged on the island of Sicily in the mid-19th century as a form of protecting and controlling local lands and agriculture and gradually transformed into a powerful criminal organization. By the mid-20th century, it had permeated politics, construction, and finance and later expanded to include drug trafficking, money laundering, and other crimes. At its core, the Mafia engages in extortion, resolving disputes between criminals, and organizing and overseeing illegal deals and transactions. The Sicilian Mafia, under the leadership of Salvatore Riina, also known as Toto Riina, got infamous for its aggressive attacks on Italian law enforcement. In Sicily, the term "Perfect Bodies" is used to distinguish the assassinations of high-ranking government officials by the Mafia from those of ordinary criminals and citizens. Their victims included police commissioners, mayors, judges, police colonels and generals, and members of Parliament. The basic group is known as a family, clan, or cosca. Each family claims sovereignty over a territory, usually a town, village, or neighborhood (borgata) of a larger city, and carries out its tribute collection activities. Although members refer to themselves as honorable men, the public generally refers to them as mafia members. By the 20th century, widespread migration from Sicily had led to the formation of mafia-style gangs in other countries, especially in the USA, and the American Mafia emerged as a branch of these gangs. Taking their name from their criminal counterparts across the Atlantic in the USA, these diaspora-based groups imitated the traditions and methods of their Sicilian ancestors to varying degrees. In recent years, the activities of the Sicilian Mafia have significantly decreased, especially murders linked to Mafia activities, because of Article 41-bis. The imprisoned bosses' communication with the outside world is tightly controlled under the regime of Article 41-bis, which limits their ability to run their operations from behind bars. Following the arrest of the alleged new boss in July 2019, a CNN article stated that the Sicilian Mafia activities in Palermo, particularly in the Sicilian town of Passo di Rigano, had become infamous for their connection to businesses such as wholesale food supply, online betting, and gambling. The report also confirmed links between Cosa Nostra and New York's Gambino crime family.

A photo of Salvatore Riina (Toto Riina):

c. Impact of Italian Mafias Worldwide

Italian organized crime is known worldwide so much that the term "Mafia" is now understood as a term referring to the organized crime world on a global scale. The mafia-type Italian organized crime syndicate poses a clear and present threat to the world, particularly to the European Union (EU). The threat they pose is unprecedented by any other organized crime group. They launder money by exploiting legal loopholes and benefiting from the services of corrupt managers and professionals and manage it through shell companies and intermediaries. They are also able to manipulate elections and appoint their own people to administrative positions even in areas far from those they control. The three Italian Mafia-type organizations, which are the Camorra, the 'Ndrangheta, and the Sicilian Mafia, exhibit common characteristics and also show certain individual traits that deserve appreciation. These mafias change their behavior and methods when operating outside their areas of origin.

Cosa Nostra is the oldest, most traditional, and most widespread manifestation of the Sicilian Mafia. Its international expansion is primarily focused on North America. In the EU, its representatives facilitate criminal activities and money laundering. Cosa Nostra's current strategy is to remain low-profile, both within and outside the territories it controls. Cosa Nostra is increasing its role in drug trafficking and frequently collaborates with other mafias. Highly skilled Cosa Nostra money launderers manage legitimate business structures and have permeated the economies of some target countries, including South Africa, Canada, the USA, Venezuela, and Spain.

The 'Ndrangheta is among the wealthiest and most powerful organized crime groups globally. With the help of its excellent relationships with producers, it holds a dominant position in the drug market. The 'Ndrangheta is seeking to colonize new territories and increase its influence over Calabrian immigrant communities. It replicates its operational structures, the 'ndrine, abroad; these structures

are still under the highest authority of the Calabrian Crime Authority. The ‘Ndrangheta has a hierarchical structure and has repeatedly demonstrated its ability to infiltrate political and economic environments and its remarkable capacity for corruption. By cleverly using its enormous crime-derived liquidity in legitimate business structures, it has managed to achieve near-monopoly status in select sectors such as construction, real estate, and transportation. The ‘Ndrangheta is primarily present in Spain, France, Belgium, the Netherlands, Germany, Switzerland, Canada, the USA, Colombia, and Australia.

The Camorra’s presence in the region exerts enormous influence. Outside their own territory, the Camorra is primarily involved in drug trafficking, cigarette smuggling, illegal waste dumping, and the sale of counterfeit goods, either procured through Chinese organized crime gangs or produced directly by the clans. They are also among the leading producers of counterfeit euros, which are then sold and circulated by other organized crime groups. The Camorra is present in Spain, France, the Netherlands, Germany, Switzerland, Eastern Europe, the USA, and Latin America.

6. Key Terms

Drug Trafficking: Illicit drug trafficking is a global black market dedicated to the sale of prohibited drugs.

Arms Trafficking: Arms trafficking is the illegal trade of smuggled arms and forms part of a wide range of illicit activities often associated with transnational criminal organizations.

Money Laundering: Money laundering is the process of transforming goods obtained from illicit activities to give them a legitimate appearance.

Extortion: Extortion is the practice of obtaining a benefit from an individual or group by coercion, usually through the threat of future psychological and physical harm.

Corruption: Corruption is a type of dishonest conduct or crime committed by a person or organization in a position of authority with the intention of obtaining unfair gain or abusing their power for their own benefit.

Extradition: The act of a competent authority (such as a state) extraditing an accused person to another authority with jurisdiction to try the accusation, in accordance with the provisions of a treaty or law.

7. Illegal Activities of Italian Mafias

a. Drugs and Arms Trafficking

Italian Mafias, especially the ‘Ndrangheta, are really famous for drugs and arms trafficking. The ‘Ndrangheta and Cosa Nostra are known to have collaborated in drug trafficking operations. It is known that it was the drug trafficking that made the ‘Ndrangheta so powerful and dangerous. It now trades on a level playing field with the largest cartels in South America and it controls %80 of the drug trafficking in Europe. On the other hand, the Camorra’s illicit drug trafficking has spread to Spain but the organization is still deeply rooted in Naples.

And for arms trafficking, once again, the ‘Ndrangheta comes front. The Italian mafia is selling rifles and other forms of weapons to IS leaders in Libya, the Italian newspaper, La Stampa reports. “After getting them from Libya, the suspected Ndrangheta gangsters sell the priceless artefacts to Russian and Asian collectors.” La Stampa added. It was also reported that the ‘Ndrangheta, which dominates Europe’s drug trafficking, collaborated with the Camorra to purchase Kalashnikov rifle and rocket launchers smuggled in from Ukraine and Moldova by the Russian Mafia.

b. Money Laundering

Experts have stated that the Italian mafia mastered complex financial operations that can impact the country’s economy, following large-scale money laundering operations carried out by various Italian mafia groups. “We saw how competent they really are, and the power they have to move the whole economy,” Sergio Nazzaro, an Italian writer and expert on the mafia said. According to the Guardia Di Finanza, virtually every major mafia group in Italy has been part of a series of schemes related to this sector, jointly laundering more than $200 million. One of the mafia that Italian authorities focused on was the Moccia of the Camorra. "One of the most powerful and dangerous Camorra organizations on the national scene." , Guardia Di Finanza said. The group is known for its ability to infiltrate the legal economy and is entrenched in the oil sector and would largely use the oil business as a method to launder money they obtained from other illicit activities. “For the collection of large cash sums deriving from fraud, the Moccia clan made use of a real parallel organization, autonomous, structured, and suitable for the recycling of their financial resources,” Guardia di Finanza said. Authorities also have uncovered two major fraud schemes run by the ‘Ndrangheta. “Two fraud systems have been ascertained, concerning the oil & gas trade, which involved 12 companies, five fuel depots and 37 road distributors,” the statement said. "The fraud system consisted in the import, mostly from Eastern Europe, of artificial petroleum products (mixtures) and lubricating oils, subsequently marketed as diesel for transport, resulting in substantial gains due to the different level of taxation.”.

c. Extortion and Corruption

In Italy, extortion and blackmail are complex criminal phenomena due to the types of perpetrators and the relationships they establish with their victims. Historically; the Camorra, the ‘Ndrangheta and the Sicilian Mafia have been deeply involved in extortion activities against legal and illegal actors in the regions where they originated and where they exerted strong control over land and people. Italian mafias use extortion as a way to control the region by infiltrating the legitimate economy and restricting the activities of criminal actors (such as drug dealers) who aren’t members of their organization. According to forensic evidence, the extortion activities of Italian mafias against businesses consist of imposing regular or temporary payments on victims or other types of transactions such as the supply of raw materials, services or labor. These transactions are directed at the victims.

Corruption is a major problem in Italy. Transparency International’s annual surveys consistently rank Italy as one of the most corrupt countries in the Eurozone. Italian Mafias play a significant role in corruption in both the public and private sectors. As Forbes notes, Italian Mafias have historically acted as guarantors for contracts in periods when justice was seen as weak. Until recently, almost every deal in the country was enforced by a “man of honor”. One source described the corruption network involving politics, business and Italian Mafias as an “unholy triangle” alternatively, viewable as a rectangle adding the Catholic Church as the fourth due to its links between Mafia and the Vatican Bank and its involvement in “complex laundering systems” that manage church funds.

8. International Cooperation Against Italian Mafias

a. Major Operations Against Italian Mafias

I-CAN: Between 2025 and 2027, international efforts to disrupt the 'Ndrangheta's global networks intensified. To counter this growing threat, the I-CAN (INTERPOL'S Cooperation Against the 'Ndrangheta) initiative was launched in 2020. Primarily funded by the Italian Ministry of Public Security and supported by countries such as Germany, I-CAN coordinates a multilateral law enforcement response. It currently utilizes INTERPOL's analytical tools and databases, which include over 65.000 entities linked to 'Ndrangheta networks. The project helps police forces share intelligence and conduct joint operations.

By early 2025, Operation I-CAN had led to the arrest of 108 members of the 'Ndrangheta. Among them were high-profile fugitives such as Edgardo Greco, convicted of two murders and apprehended in France after 16 years on the run. Another was Rocco Morabito, one of the world's biggest drug traffickers, who had escaped from prison in Uruguay and been recaptured in Brazil.

I-CAN also played a significant role in Operation Eureka (2023), a major investigation spanning six European countries. The operation uncovered approximately $27 million in illicit funds linked to drugs, weapons and money laundering, resulting in over 150 arrests. By fostering intelligence sharing, real-time access and coordinated action, I-CAN stands out as one of the most advanced global strategies in combating the 'Ndrangheta and its criminal empire.

German-Italian Operation (April 2025): In April 2025, a large-scale joint operation by German and Italian authorities arrested 36 people suspected of being linked to the powerful 'Ndrangheta mafia across Germany, Among those detained was a 46-year-old police officer from the Aalen Police Department, accused of leaking classified information. The raids, carried out at 40 different locations across states including North Rhine-Westphalia and Baden-Württemberg, were part of a broader investigation that began in 2021 targeting the Calabria-based group, which operates extensive criminal networks across Europe and beyond.

Operation Eureka: On May 3, 2023, authorities carried out a large-scale, coordinated operation across ten countries. In this operation, 132 members of the 'Ndrangheta were arrested; this is considered the largest international operation against the group to date. The operation, carried out with the support of Europol and Eurojust, involved more than 2.770 police officers. Raids were conducted in Belgium, Germany, Italy, France, Portugal, Spain, Slovenia, Romania, Brazil and Panama. The targets were powerful clans based in San Luca, Calabria, a stronghold of the 'Ndrangheta. These families were involved in a wide range of crimes, including drug and arms trafficking, money laundering, tax evasion and providing refuge to fugitives. Some of those arrested were on the EU's Most Wanted list.

The network was found to be collaborating with Colombian Gulf Klan cartels, arms suppliers in Pakistan and criminal organizations in Ecuador and Brazil, using a remittance system to transfer illicit gains and pay for large shipments of cocaine. Criminal activities were laundered through investments in real estate, hotels, supermarkets and car wash businesses across Europe and South America. The operation also uncovered schemes involving the exchange of Soviet-made Kalashnikov rifles for cocaine, demonstrating the group's deep involvement in arms trafficking. Operation Eureka also

revealed the increasing use of encrypted communication platforms by criminal networks and the growing capacity of European agencies to intercept and analyze them.

Europol analyzed encrypted communications and deployed mobile teams to support the raids. Eurojust helped establish joint investigative teams and issued European Investigation Orders. It also coordinated actions in real time. This operation, known as Operation Eureka, was a major success. a significant step in dismantling the 'Ndrangheta's cross-border financial and operational networks.

INTERPOL's Silver Notice: In addition to traditional arrest-focused operations, international law enforcement agencies are increasingly targeting the financial infrastructure of organized crime. A significant development in this area occurred in January 2025 with INTERPOL's release of its first Silver Notice; this new tool aims to identify and recover assets linked to serious crimes, including mafia-related activities. While Red Notices are used to locate and arrest individuals, Silver Notices focus on tracking and seizing illegally obtained assets. These include cryptocurrency wallets, offshore accounts, vehicles and real estate. Given that over %99 of global criminal assets remain unclaimed, this initiative marks a major shift. The goal is to weaken mafia groups by cutting off their financial power.

This notice is extremely important, especially for groups like the 'Ndrangheta, the Camorra and the Sicilian Mafia, which make large investments in legitimate businesses to launder their profits, as it can be used in drug trafficking, money laundering, corruption and organized crime cases.

b. The Future of Combating Italian Mafias

Despite significant breakthroughs in recent years, including high-profile arrests and new tools such as INTERPOL's Silver Notice, the fight against Italian Mafia groups remains complex and urgent. As these organizations become more global and sophisticated, law enforcement agencies need to constantly evolve to stay one step ahead. Groups like the 'Ndrangheta, the Camorra and the Sicilian Mafia have demonstrated extraordinary adaptability. They embed themselves in fragile economies and utilize cryptocurrencies for money transfers. They exploit international smuggling routes to expand their sphere of influence. Their use of encrypted communication and complex financial networks makes them difficult to track. Corruption by state actors further complicates matters. These tactics will continue to pose challenges for intelligence and law enforcement agencies worldwide.

New tools like Silver Notice could play a significant role in the future. When expanded beyond the pilot phase, they could help target the financial lifelines of mafia groups. Combined with AI-powered financial forensics and blockchain analysis, they offer new possibilities. Stronger asset seizure laws would also be helpful. Together, these tools allow law enforcement to strike where it will cause the most damage: money.

9. Questions a Resolution Paper Must Address

1. How can member states align their national laws with Article 416-bis to ensure that being a member of an Italian Mafia group is considered a crime internationally?

2. What international measures could be taken to stop the flow of drugs caused by Italian Mafias in Europe?

3. How could the Silver Notice be used to stop Italian Mafia groups from money laundering?

4. What strategies should be used to prevent Italian Mafia groups from taking over foreign countries' economies?

5. How can international organizations stop Italian Mafia groups from trading heavy weapons from conflict zones?

6. How can INTERPOL facilitate extradition of mafia bosses hiding in countries that do not have an agreement with Italy?

7. What protocols should be established to address strategic partnerships between Italian Mafia groups and foreign organized crime groups?

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